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WITH SHARIF STILL IN EXILE, BHUTTO'S MUTE RESPONSE TO THE EMERGENCY MAKES PEOPLE BELIEVE THAT SHE IS PARTY TO THE DECISION



AP PHOTO/FAREED KHAN

house arrest, observers have pointedly commented at the lack of street response from two of the most potent political forces, Bhutto's Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) and Maulana Fazlur Rahman's Jamiat-e-Ulema-e-Islam (JUI). Many an eyebrow has also been raised at the fact that most of their party members have been spared arrests. While there has not been any statement from Rahman, most people are keenly looking at the cautious "wait and see" approach adopted by Bhutto, who dashed back from Dubai—where she had gone three days earlier to meet her children—hours after the proclamation of Emergency. Publicly Bhutto has condemned what

UNCERTAIN FUTURE: Sharif (top); Bhutto have a lot at stake

she has termed "a mini-Martial Law" and called on Musharraf to hold elections. But most people are convinced there is some level of duplicity in her statements and that she is still angling for an alliance with the General that would benefit her personally.

Former Supreme Court judge Wajihuddin Ahmad, who was a presidential candidate against Musharraf in the recent presidential elections and the main appellant in the case against him as well, claims a strong PPP link in the imposition of martial rule. "General Musharraf has acted in league with the beneficiaries of the

National Reconciliation Ordinance (NRO)," he says, referring to the controversial decree that granted amnesty to Bhutto and others from corruption cases. Certainly, it had been speculated that the Supreme Court, which had taken up challenges to NRO, would strike down the Ordinance as against the principles of justice. Bhutto, on her part, had never tried to hide her unhappiness with the judicial activism of Chief Justice Iftikhar Chaudhry and her distrust of his ambitions. She was also not very pleased with her party member, current Supreme Court Bar President Aitzaz Ahsan going all out to defend Chaudhry as his lawyer and build him up as a public hero. The newly-appointed head of the apex court—Justice Abdul Hameed Dogar who replaced Chaudhry—is a judge whom she herself had appointed to the high court in 1994.

There are indications that Bhutto may still be willing to strike a deal with Musharraf in return for further political advantages. Pointing out that she was always willing to aid him in his eligibility issue by helping him pass a constitutional amendment "if he was willing to pay the political price that we demanded," she told an American reporter that the door for negotiations was still open. "We are talking about revival of the Constitution, up-front retirement as chief of army staff and up-front elections on schedule, announced by November 15, and held by January 15. If he is prepared to take these measures, along with some others, then we can say that all that has occurred, we will let it drop," she told an international newsmagazine.

In fact, many political analysts have labelled Bhutto's protests against General Musharraf's actions as "scripted." Veteran politician and former air marshal Asghar Khan, who heads his own small political party, claims that Bhutto will continue to make "superficial noises" against the imposition of martial rule but will eventually join up with General Musharraf. "The exact timing of the Emergency may not have been done in consultation with Benazir," says Aamer Ahmed Khan, BBC Online's South Asia bureau chief based in